

A cystoscopy lets your care team look inside your urethra and bladder. A thin scope with a tiny camera and light is passed gently through the opening where urine comes out. It helps find the cause of blood in the urine, infections, narrowing or other bladder problems. It is also used to check on a repair.

About This Test

A **cystoscope** is a thin tube with a camera on the end. There are two kinds:

- A **flexible (bendable) scope** is usually used in the office while you are awake, with numbing gel.
- A **rigid (straight) scope** is often used in the operating room while you are asleep, so a problem can also be treated. It is sometimes used in the office with numbing gel.

Sterile fluid is run in to gently open the bladder so the walls can be seen clearly. You may have a cystoscopy to:

- Find the cause of **blood in the urine** or repeated infections
- Look for a **narrowing (stricture)**, a stone or a growth
- Check how a repair is healing, or take a small sample (biopsy)
- Place, check or remove a **stent** or stitch

Is It Safe?

Yes. Cystoscopy is one of the most common urology tests, and the risk is low. Most people have only brief discomfort. Side effects such as short-lived burning, a little bleeding, trouble urinating or a urine infection are uncommon and usually mild.

Learn the Terms

Cystoscope

A thin scope with a camera and light used to look inside the bladder.

Bladder

The muscular sac that stores urine until you urinate.

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Flexible or rigid

A bendable scope, or a straight scope that can also be used for treatment.

Numbing gel

Medicine placed in the urethra so the scope passes more comfortably.

Biopsy

A small tissue sample looked at under a microscope.

Stent

A soft tube that holds a passage open. It may be placed or removed during the test.

Post-void residual

The amount of urine left in the bladder after you urinate.

Will it hurt? With a flexible scope you may feel brief pressure or stinging as it passes. The numbing gel helps, and an office test is usually over in a few minutes. If you are asleep for the test, you feel nothing during it. Tell the team any time you are uncomfortable.

How to Get Ready

- For an **office test**, you can usually **eat, drink and take your usual medicines**, and drive yourself home.
- For a test **under anesthesia**, follow your surgery instructions about eating, drinking and medicines, and arrange a ride home.
- You may be asked for a **urine sample** to check for infection. Most people having a simple office test do not need an antibiotic. Some people do, based on their health or the treatment planned.

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Take a **blood thinner**
- Have signs of a **urine infection** (burning or fever). The test may need to be moved.
- Have allergies, an implant such as an artificial sphincter, or a narrowing that made a past scope hard to pass

What Happens During the Test

- 1 You lie back and the team helps you into position. The area is cleaned and numbing gel is placed.
- 2 The scope is passed gently through the urethra into the bladder.
- 3 Sterile fluid runs in to open the bladder, and the lining is checked all the way around.
- 4 If a treatment, biopsy or stent change is planned, it is done. Then the scope is removed.

After the Test

- After an office test, you can usually go back to **normal activities right away**. After anesthesia, you rest and need a ride home.
- Mild **burning when you urinate** for a day or so is common. Drinking extra water helps.
- A **pink tinge** in the urine for a short time is common and usually clears within a day.

Call the office that did your test if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Burning or pain that gets worse instead of better
- A weak stream, or you feel you are not emptying

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- Your urine looks like red wine or has clots
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Cystoscopy is a quick, low-risk look inside your bladder and urethra.
2. An office test needs little preparation. For a test under anesthesia, arrange a ride.
3. Mild burning or pink urine for a day is normal. Drink extra water.